as supporters of the Burma Socialist Programme Party.[97] In 1959, a Rohingya student association was one of the approved groups at Rangoon University[98] (see Appendix 4).

To all intents and purpose, the Rohingyas were treated like any other ethnic group and it is reasonable to assume the government intended to normalise their status at some stage. Equally, there was no denial that the Rohingyas existed as an ethnic group. A military report from 1961 describes the Muslim population in the Mayu frontier district (bordering East Pakistan) as Rohingyas.[99] The 1961 census indicated the Mayu district was 75 per cent Rohingya,[100] and this district was formally transferred from the frontier administrative districts to the Ministry of Home Affairs and incorporated into Rakhine province. This treatment is in contrast to other ethnically dominated border districts and indicates that relations in the area were relatively normal, with no ongoing armed revolt.

Instead, the main targets of discrimination at this stage were those who were deemed to be Indian migrants, who were denied citizenship and treated as foreigners. This in itself was contentious under the UN Charter, but was aimed at the mostly Hindu Indian migrants who were brought by the British to Burma to work in the rubber plantations (work that few Burmese were prepared to undertake). However, this distinction between the labour migrants and the Rohingyas was slowly eroded after the military took power in 1962.

Military rule, 1962–88

Up until 1965 the military regime did little to attack the Rohingyas directly and some Rohingyas continued to sit in parliament supporting the goals of the Burmese Road to Socialism. A 1964 school encyclopaedia describes the ethnic makeup of the Mayyu region as ‘75% of Rohingya and a few of Rakhine, Dai Nat, Myo, KhMee. Rohingya are Islam’.[101]

However, the Rohingyas were steadily losing their existing rights, and the 1974 Emergency Immigration Act imposed ethnicity-based identity cards (National Registration Certificates), with the Rohingyas only being eligible for Foreign Registration Cards (non-national cards).[102] It is important to note that this renewal of attacks on the Rohingyas came at a time when the economy was in crisis and the regime needed to distract